was released from jail in December 2012 after serving 11 years in different jails, stated that he formed HM on 15 February 1989 at Hajibugh Beerwa in Budgam district (Pakistan Observer, 2012). The name Hizbul Mujahideen was an amalgam of the names of Syed Ahmad Shaheed's Tehreekul Mujahideen and Afghanistan's Hizb-e-Islami led by Gulbuddin Hekmatyar. HM was reportedly headquartered in Muzaffarabad, in Pakistan-administered Kashmir.

There were different opinions about the strength of the group. According to South Asia Terrorism Portal, the total strength of HM activists was about 1,500 (SATP, 2013).

Some of its activists received arms training in Afghanistan camps. Nevertheless, its leadership never identified itself with either Al Qaeda or the Taliban. It was included in the 'Foreign Terrorist Organisations' list by the US Department of State under the Prevention of Terrorism Act of 2002 on 1 May 2003.

It was considered one of the most prominent militant groups in the region because of its effectiveness and high-tech tactics used against the Indian forces and the broad network of its organisational base. It was a well-organised and structured militant group as it formulated its own codified constitution that depicted its organisational structure, rules and regulations for the functioning of the group and its objectives. HM established a five-member Majlis-e-Shura to formulate the policy affairs of the group (Rana, 2009). It had considerable resources available, particularly in the 1990s in its fight against the Indian security forces. Some smaller groups operating in Indian-held Kashmir, such as Zia Tigers, Al Hamza, Maududi Squad and Ansar ul Islam which were linked with Jamaat-e-Islami (JI), merged into the Hizbul Mujahideen, while other factions merged into it later.

HM was blamed to be backed by Pakistan as it demanded the unification of Kashmir under Pakistani control as opposed to the Jammu Kashmir Liberation Front (JKLF), which advocated for complete independence rather than accession to Pakistan (SATP).

HM's policy was based on two points. The first was related to their ideology, which clearly stated that HM would respect everyone who respected their concept of Jihad and would not tolerate opposition to this concept or subversion of their ideology. Secondly, it maintained that the group would use its weapons against its enemy only and none else.